

Tertullian, also, says of his right to the New Testament Scriptures, “I hold sure title-deeds from the original owners themselves... I am the heir of the apostles. Just as they carefully prepared their will and testament, and committed it to a trust... even so I hold it.”¹

Irenaeus

In order to ensure accuracy in transcription, authors would sometimes add at the close of their literary works an adjuration directed to future copyists. So, for example, Irenaeus attached to the close of his treatise *On the Ogdoad* the following note: “I adjure you who shall copy out this book, by our Lord Jesus Christ and by his glorious advent when he comes to judge the living and the dead, that you compare what you transcribe, and correct it carefully against this manuscript from which you copy; and also that you transcribe this adjuration and insert it in the copy.”²

If Irenaeus took such extreme precautions for the accurate transmission of his own work, how much more would he be concerned for the accurate copying of the Word of God? In fact, he demonstrates his concern for the accuracy of the text by defending the traditional reading of a **single letter**. The question is whether John the Apostle wrote $\chi\zeta\varsigma$ (666) or $\chi\iota\varsigma$ (616) in Revelation 13:18. Irenaeus asserts that 666 is found “in all the most approved and ancient copies” and that “those men who saw John face to face” bear witness to it. And he warns those who made the change (of a single letter) that “there shall be no light punishment upon him who either adds or subtracts anything from the Scripture” (xxx.1). Presumably Irenaeus is applying Revelation 22:18-19.

Considering Polycarp’s intimacy with John, his personal copy of Revelation would most probably have been taken from the Autograph. And considering Irenaeus’ veneration for Polycarp his personal copy of Revelation was probably taken from Polycarp’s. Although Irenaeus evidently was no longer able to refer to the Autograph (not ninety years after it was written!) he was clearly in a position to identify a faithful copy and to declare with certainty the original reading—this in 186 AD. Which brings us to Tertullian.

¹ *Prescription against Heretics*, 37. I have used the translation done by Peter Holmes in Vol. III of *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*.

² B.M. Metzger, *The Text of the New Testament* (London: Oxford University Press, 1964), p. 21.